

STEPPE HORSEMEN

THE MONGOLS AT WAR

Under the leadership of Genghis Khan from the early 13th century, the Mongols created the largest empire in history. Their secret was the ability to blend the traditional fighting tactics of nomadic horsemen with technology adopted from the settled civilizations that they subjugated.

Born Temüjin, the son of a tribal chief, the future Genghis Khan spent two decades uniting the various Mongol and Turkic peoples of eastern Central Asia. Although they had similar lifestyles – living in tents and in close proximity to their horses – the Mongols, Merkits, Naimans, Keraites, Tatars, and Uighurs were traditionally hostile to one another. However, using a combination of savage warfare and cunning diplomacy, Temüjin united them into a vast steppe confederation. In 1206, the tribes formally acknowledged his authority and he assumed the title Genghis Khan, or “lord of all”. With a huge army at his disposal, Genghis embarked on campaigns that reached from Beijing (Zhongdu) in China, to the wealthy Central Asian cities of Samarkand and Bukhara (in modern-day Uzbekistan), before his death in 1227.

The Mongols’ style of warfare originated from hunting. With their powerful composite bows and sturdy, nimble horses, large groups of riders would pursue herds across the steppe, then encircle and kill the animals with arrows; this is also how they attacked their enemy in battle. The Mongols had none of the obsession with personal bravery and honour that governed medieval European knights at the time. A traditional steppe horseman would use his bow to kill from a distance whenever possible, instead of risking his life in a close-quarters encounter. Similarly, Mongol commanders directed battles from a position of safety, using flags, smoke signals, and trumpets to convey orders; they considered it foolish to risk personally leading their men into combat. However, they also learned

to augment their traditional mounted bowmen with armoured cavalry equipped with swords and lances, and protected by metal armour, instead of their usual felt or silk tunics. Rather than avoiding close combat, this heavy cavalry would charge an enemy already weakened by the bowmen, and deliver the final, crushing blow.

Overall, their approach to warfare was ruthlessly practical: they would lure the enemy into a position of weakness, then destroy them. Speed of manoeuvre was therefore of the essence. Travelling light and living off the land, they could overcome the more cumbersome armies of settled civilizations.

THE OLD AND THE NEW

However, if traditional steppe warfare was the foundation for Genghis Khan’s empire, then its expansion was strongly based on new technology adopted from conquered territories in China and the Muslim world. From Beijing in 1214–15 to Baghdad in 1258, the Mongols demonstrated their skill at siege warfare, battering city walls with projectiles hurled by mangonels and trebuchets. They were also pioneers in the use of gunpowder as a military explosive and incendiary material, using primitive bombs hurled by catapult, and hand-held devices that were ancestors of the flamethrower and the handgun.

At their peak the Mongols were a near-unstoppable military force, but their high-casualty tactics prevented the long-term consolidation of their far-flung realms. By the end of the 14th century, the mighty empire that Genghis had so skilfully founded was reduced to fragments.

WARFARE ON THE STEPPE

After the death of Genghis Khan, the Mongols often fought one another in a series of bloody power struggles. Here sword-wielding Mongol cavalry pursue defeated rivals, who are shooting their composite bows from the saddle.

